

Week 4 Lit Example Reader

JULIUS CAESAR: THE MIDDLE TERM OF FUTURE DANGER

Purpose: This reader gives Julius Caesar passages for applying Week 4's logic habit: map a practical syllogism, name the major term, minor term, and middle term, and test whether the middle term really connects the premises to the conclusion.

What to watch for: Brutus and Cassius do not merely express feelings about Caesar. They try to make political fear look like proof. The logical question is: *what term is supposed to bridge the evidence to the conclusion?*

Before the Passages: The Week 4 Logic Tool

A syllogism uses two premises to support a conclusion. In a practical literary argument, the exact wording may be messy, but the map still matters:

- **Major term:** the predicate of the conclusion.
- **Minor term:** the subject of the conclusion.
- **Middle term:** the term that appears in the premises and is supposed to connect the minor term to the major term.

The middle term is the pressure point. If it does not truly apply, the conclusion may only look proved.

Passage 1: Act 2, Scene 1 — Brutus and the Serpent's Egg

Context: Brutus is alone, thinking about whether Caesar should be killed before he becomes king. Caesar has not yet become a tyrant. Brutus has to reason from what Caesar may become.

Brutus. It must be by his death: and for my part,
I know no personal cause to spurn at him,
But for the general. He would be crown'd:
How that might change his nature, there's the question.
It is the bright day that brings forth the adder;
And that craves wary walking. Crown him?—that;—
And then, I grant, we put a sting in him,
That at his will he may do danger with.
The abuse of greatness is, when it disjoins
Remorse from power: and, to speak truth of Caesar,
I have not known when his affections sway'd
More than his reason. But 'tis a common proof,
That lowliness is young ambition's ladder,

Whereto the climber-upward turns his face;
But when he once attains the upmost round,
He then unto the ladder turns his back,
Looks in the clouds, scorning the base degrees
By which he did ascend. So Caesar may.
Then, lest he may, prevent. And, since the quarrel
Will bear no colour for the thing he is,
Fashion it thus; that what he is, augmented,
Would run to these and these extremities:
And therefore think him as a serpent's egg
Which, hatch'd, would, as his kind, grow mischievous,
And kill him in the shell.

Reader Notes

Here is your most assisted example. Brutus's likely conclusion is that Caesar should be stopped before he is crowned. A possible middle term is something like *one who will probably become a dangerous tyrant if given supreme power*. Notice how much weight that term carries. Brutus admits he has no personal cause against Caesar and has not known Caesar's passions to rule his reason; then he shifts to what ambition commonly does.

Reading task: Underline Brutus's conclusion. Box the lines where he admits what he has not proved about Caesar. Star the image that makes future danger feel vivid.

Passage 2: Act 1, Scene 2 — Cassius and the Colossus

Context: Cassius wants Brutus to resist Caesar. His argument is less orderly than Brutus’s orchard speech. Watch how he moves from Caesar’s greatness, Roman honor, and Brutus’s family name toward a political conclusion.

Cassius. Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world
Like a Colossus, and we petty men
Walk under his huge legs and peep about
To find ourselves dishonourable graves.
Men at some time are masters of their fates:
The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars,
But in ourselves, that we are underlings.
Brutus and Caesar: what should be in that “Caesar”?
Why should that name be sounded more than yours?
Write them together, yours is as fair a name;
Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well;
Weigh them, it is as heavy; conjure with ’em,
Brutus will start a spirit as soon as Caesar.
Now, in the names of all the gods at once,
Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed,
That he is grown so great? Age, thou art shamed!
Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!
When could they say till now, that talk’d of Rome,
That her wide walls encompass’d but one man?

Reader Notes

Cassius gives you evidence to sort, not a finished diagram. He points to Caesar’s public greatness, Brutus’s equal name, Roman shame, and the danger of living under one man. Do not let the insult or imagery do the mapping for you. Decide which term is supposed to connect Caesar’s position to the conclusion Cassius wants.

Reading task: Mark three phrases Cassius uses as evidence. In the margin, write one possible middle term, but do not decide yet whether it is proved.

How to Use These Passages on the Worksheet

The worksheet asks you to map Shakespearean reasoning into premises, conclusion, and terms. Quote briefly if useful, but the answer should be a logic map, not a plot summary.

Strong college-level answers should name the conclusion, identify the middle term, and explain whether the middle term is proved strongly enough to carry the argument.